



coast, and their land stretches up to the beginning of the highlands. They share many cultural similarities from village to village, such as the elaborate initiation rites and the highly developed art and architectural

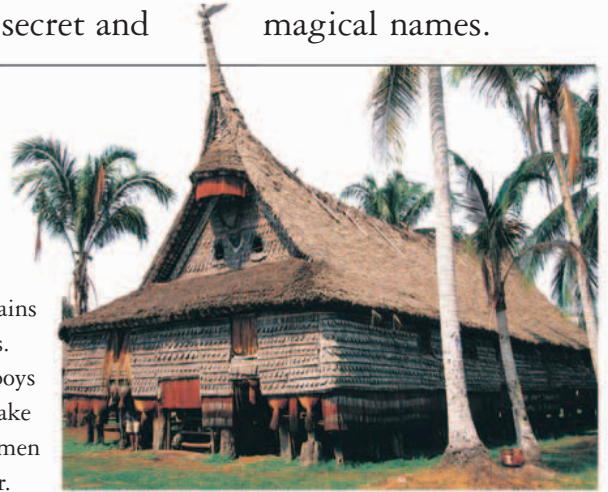
styles. Secrecy is an important part of life; the older males get, the more they are allowed to learn. Older men often hold debates challenging each other's knowledge of the secret and magical names.

Male initiation

The process of males initiating boys into manhood is of enormous importance in Sepik societies and there are many rituals connected to it. The initiation has many levels where each boy is taught obligations and secret rituals, and learns about the mythical journeys of their ancestors. It is often years before a boy becomes a man.

HAUS TAMBARAN

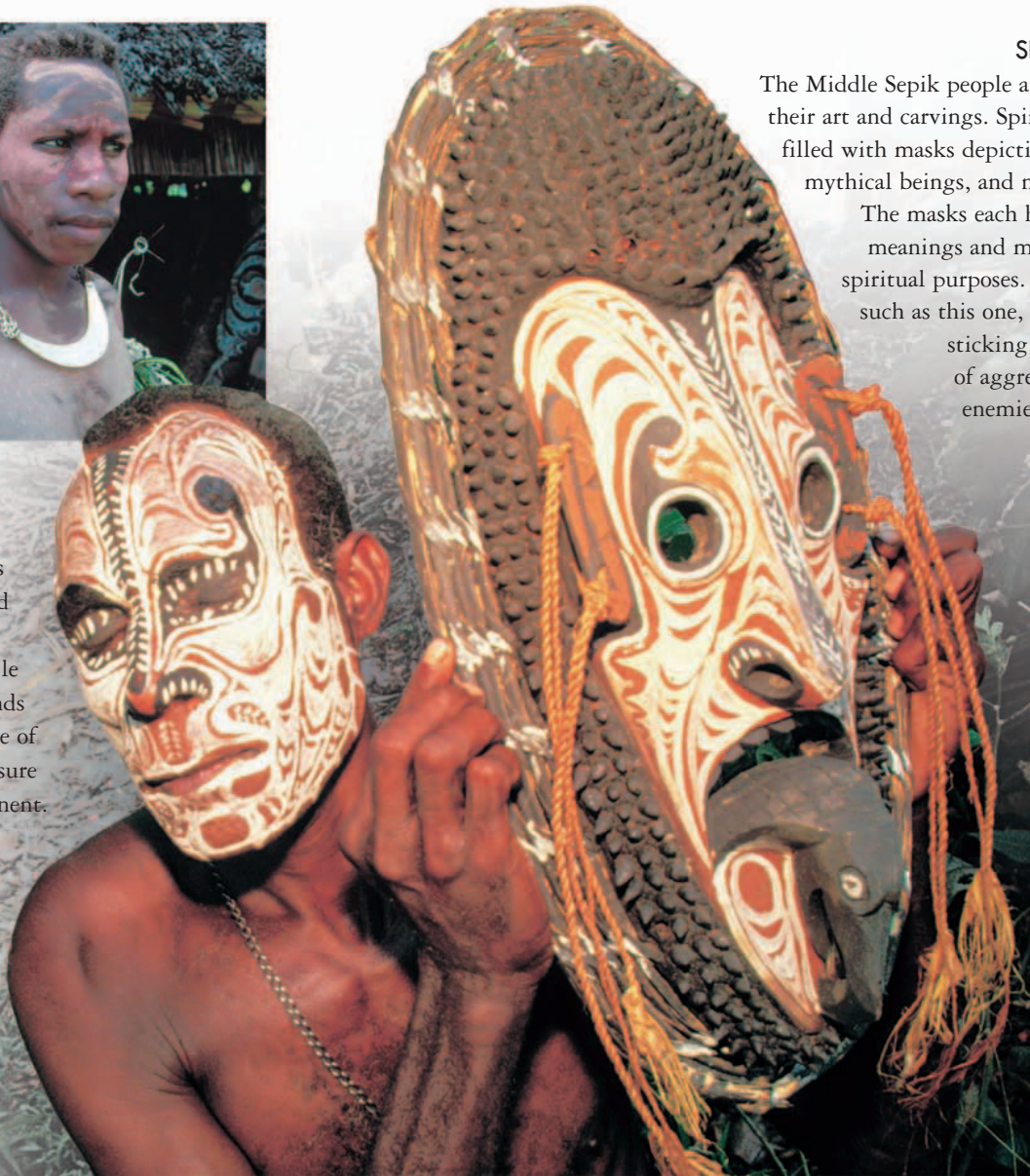
Every village has a spiritual house called a *haus tambaran*. The building can have one or two stories and contains many intricate carvings. It is where the young boys learn rituals that will take them to manhood. Women are not allowed to enter.



INITIATION SCARRING

In some Sepik groups a young male must learn about pain—this involves scarring. This boy has had his skin cut deeply and made to resemble crocodile skin. Afterward the wounds are rubbed with a mixture of ashes, oil, and mud to ensure that the pattern is permanent.

Only certain powerful men may lower the savi masks from their storage in the *haus tambaran*.



SEPIK MASKS

The Middle Sepik people are famous for their art and carvings. Spirit houses are filled with masks depicting ancestors, mythical beings, and nature spirits.

The masks each have complex meanings and many different spiritual purposes. Some masks, such as this one, have tongues sticking out as a sign of aggression toward enemies of the clan.